



Pics: PRIME VOLLEYBALL LEAGUE

from the two novelties, behind only Goa Guardians (39) and Ahmedabad Defenders (33).

The other side of the net

With the two finalists dominating proceedings in the group stage, the remaining teams were left to scrap for the last two knockout spots. Ahmedabad handed the Meteors their only defeat of the phase to qualify third, while a four-way tie emerged for the final spot.

Eventually, the Guardians scraped through thanks to their superior set difference, leaving Delhi Toofans, Kochi Blue Spikers and Kolkata ThunderBolts to lick their wounds.

However, the steepest drop-off belonged to last edition's winner, Calicut Heroes, who finished bottom of the table. The team failed to cope after losing MVP Jerome Vinith to the Blitz in the auction and managed just one win in seven matches.

Meanwhile, Vinith — the joint-most expensive buy in the auction — put in a strong shift with 102 points, but his efforts went unrewarded as the Blitz finished eighth out of ten teams.

The path ahead

Having four different champions

in as many seasons is enough to dispel any doubts about the league's competitiveness. Furthermore, the addition of new teams each year reflects growing interest in the sport and hints at a shift in the right direction.

But on the flip side, the fact that the three teams led by foreign coaches reached the knockouts raises questions about the standard of Indian coaching. In the final days of the tournament, Lee asserted that there is a lot of room for improvement.

"From the very first year I was here as a player, I was always pushing to bring some international perspective — different minds to help the game develop. And I think year after year, you've seen these foreign coaches come in and really have a big impact on the players and on the league," Lee noted.

"I feel Indian coaches need to start integrating more closely with the foreign coaches to really help expedite the learning curve," he added. And while the PVL provides a valuable platform to identify talent, nurturing them stands as the bigger hurdle. Meteors head coach Van

Honour board



Most Valuable Player: Joel Benjamin (Bengaluru Torpedoes)
Emerging Player of the Season: Om Lad Vasant (Mumbai Meteors)
Best Attacker of the Season: Joel Benjamin
Best Server of the Season: Sethu TR (Bengaluru Torpedoes)
Best Setter of the Season: Om Lad Vasant
Best Libero of the Season: P Prabakaran (Ahmedabad Defenders)
Best Blocker of the Season: Prince (Goa Guardians)
Best Coach of the Season: David Lee (Bengaluru Torpedoes)

Star performers



Top scorers

- Joel Benjamin (Bengaluru Torpedoes) — 115 points
- Shubham Chaudhary (Mumbai Meteors) — 109 points
- Jerome Vinith C (Chennai Blitz) — 102 points

Top blockers

- Prince (Goa Guardians) — 20 points
- Petter Alstad Østvik (Mumbai Meteors) — 17 points
- Shikhar Singh (Hyderabad Black Hawks) — 14 block points

Wezel, who specialises in player development, highlighted the need for a structured national programme.

"I think the clubs or the franchises did a really good job with creating this (league). But that's step one. The rest of the year, there needs to be a really good national team programme," he explained.

With the Asian Games coming up next year, India will have to get its act together soon if it hopes to secure its first volleyball medal since 1986. For now, the PVL is sustainable enough to generate fervour for the sport in the country. But what follows will be crucial in determining how far Indian volleyball can truly go.